

BEFORE

As the glacial period of the Ice Age <<22–23 came to an end, conditions around the world improved for human life and the hunter-gatherer lifestyle began to die out.

OUT OF THE ICE AGE

Many of the advances in civilization were spurred on by **global warming**, which gave new opportunities to humankind.

EXPANSION

Human populations increased and spread as areas that had been glacial became temperate.

AGE OF TRANSITION

After the Ice Age, **large game animals died out** in many areas, and people turned to smaller animals and wild plant foods. Following a drought about 13,000 years ago, hunting bands in southwest Asia began planting wild wheat, barley, and other grasses to supplement strains of what grew in the wild.

BEGINNING OF FOOD PRODUCTION

Although people still lived as hunter-gatherers, moving around seasonally in search of food, by 12,000 years ago some groups had begun to exploit and control their own food supplies.

First Harvest

Everyone in the world lived by hunting and gathering 12,000 years ago. But only 6,000 years later, virtually every human society with the ability to farm and herd animals produced its own food.

Agriculture was not “invented” by one person in a sudden flash of genius. Hunting groups would have been aware that seeds germinated when they were planted in the soil. The switch from the hunter-gatherer lifestyle to one of agriculture and animal domestication was one that happened independently in various cultures around the world. It was partly prompted by climate change and was a momentous step forward for humankind—civilization as we know it today stems from the changes that took place from about 12,000 years ago.

In the area known as “the Fertile Crescent,” which includes Turkey, Syria, and Iraq, people began to domesticate goats, sheep, and pigs by living in close proximity to wild herds and controlling

their movements. Plants were gradually adapted from their wild varieties into crops that were tended and harvested. Einkorn, a variety of wheat, was the first domesticated cereal and was grown in the Fertile Crescent. The genetic changes to cereal grasses and animals that resulted from domestication occurred over a relatively short time.

NEOLITHIC The last part of the Stone Age period, beginning c. 10,000 BCE in the Middle East, c. 5500 BCE in central Europe, and c. 4500 BCE in northern Europe. The introduction of farming is a key characteristic of the Neolithic.

Key sites for early farming include Gobekli Tepe, Jericho, Çatalhöyük, and ‘Ain Ghazal. In Abu Hureyra in the Euphrates Valley (modern Syria), a small foraging settlement became a compact farming community of mud-brick houses separated by courtyards and narrow alleyways. As the plants they had sought out became harder to find due to the drier climate, the people there began to cultivate the cereal rye. They

Corn, domesticated in central America by 5000 BCE, developed from a wild grass, teosinte, and is still found in Mexico. As it spread throughout much of the Americas, farmers developed strains that adapted to local conditions such as arid environments.



Potatoes are a highland Andean crop, domesticated at an unknown date, but before 5000 BCE. Farmers in the Andes grew numerous potato varieties, adapted to different microenvironments high in the mountains. Potatoes were introduced to Europe in the 17th century.



HOW WE KNOW

TEETH AND BONES

The remains of domestic and wild animals can tell us a lot about the diet and lifestyle of our ancestors. By examining jaws and the growth patterns in teeth, one can establish the age and sex of an animal and whether it was wild or domesticated. From human remains we can learn a lot about diet and lifestyle. For example, the teeth of people from Abu Hureyra (see above) show heavy wear associated with eating ground cereals.



also continued to hunt gazelles, and keep sheep. Analysis of bones (see left) has revealed that the number of domesticated sheep gradually outnumbered wild animals, and ground cereals became part of the diet. At Göbekli Tepe in Turkey, examples of what may be the earliest stone temples, dating from c. 9000 BCE, have been discovered. This was a community on the verge of becoming a permanent village with structured belief systems.

South and East Asia

Agriculture developed independently in South Asia. It is likely to have emerged in the Indus Valley of modern

Pakistan, where farming villages such as Mehgarh were well established by 6000 BCE. Farmers in the Yangtze Valley in southern China had domesticated wild rice by at least 8000 BCE, probably at about the same time as along the Ganges River in India. In China, the Huang He (Yellow River) valley was an early center of millet and cereal cultivation, perhaps as early as 7000 BCE. Chinese agriculture became highly organized and intensive over later centuries, especially in the south. Northern Chinese farmers had to contend with frequent droughts and floods. In spite of these challenges, the sophisticated Yangshao village culture